than religious intent. The mysteries of the unknown and the unexplored have led me to search for yetis in the Himalayas and for the lost land of Shambhala in far western Tibet, to trace the footsteps of the Chinese pilgrims Faxian and Xuanzang and, more recently, to track down the minor and major rock edicts and pillar edicts of the great emperor Ashoka, scattered far and wide across India, Pakistan and Afghanistan.

This travelling was never about gaining merit or the absolution of sins. It was always the journey that mattered, and what these travels could tell me about the country and its history – a history so alluring, so epic as to keep drawing me back. There is so damn much of it, and so much still unexamined, still disputed, still buried and waiting to be brought back into the light.

So it has gone on for half a century. In the process I have been drawn ever deeper into Indian India, to which I'd like to think I have learned to expose my inner self as much as the twenty-year-old Rudyard Kipling did when he began his night walks into Indian Lahore in the 1880s, of which he wrote in a letter to a friend:

> I am now deeply involved with the people of the land. I hunt and rummage among 'em, knowing Lahore City – that wonderful, dirty, mysterious ant hill – blind-fold, and wandering through it like Haroon-Al-Rashid in search of strange things. India is now my own place, where I find heat and smells of oil and spices, and puffs of temple incense, and sweat and darkness, and dirt and lust and cruelty, and, above all, things wonderful. I am in love with the country and would sooner write about her than anything else.[2]

I, too, love the land of my birth, and have been lucky enough to be allowed to write about her these past forty years. However, the fact is that I know far more about North